

**THE SOCIETY LADY  
WANTED ME TO  
MONITOR HER  
“CHEATING” HUSBAND.  
BUT I FOUND OUT THAT  
IT WAS SHE WHO  
WAS HAVING AN  
EXTRAMARITAL AFFAIR.**

sent me to Allahabad to help out with a case of bank embezzlement.” She cracked the case and found her calling. In the 1990s, Bhavna Paliwal, who runs Tejas Detectives in Delhi, got fed up with journalism and responded to a newspaper advertisement, seeking a “lady detective”. When she solved her first case with flying colours, the agency created a new women’s wing and put her in charge.

What explains their emergence? Ask the tough-gal brigade, and they point to their personality quirks. Although the fictional heroines have special skills—Swaminathan’s Lalli is a police officer and their last resort when it comes to murders and Prabhu’s Sonia Samarth uses intricate astrological charts to trace crimes—the real-life women took to sleuthing by instinct. Pandit thinks unsolved mysteries challenge the “fierce streak of obstinacy” she was born with. “I like to do new and different things every day,” says Malathy. To Paliwal, the lure of doing “something different” proves irresistible. Lahiri, who goes into the field on her motorbike, thinks she is inquisitive and adventurous by nature.

Below the surface, it’s the changing face of the Indian family that has brought them to the forefront. Unlike Lalli or Sonia, the real-life women don’t really get to solve murders. They investigate the various disjunctions and disharmonies at work beneath the normal veneer of everyday relationships. Not surprisingly, most detective agencies with lady detectives advertise “pre-post matrimonial, family problem, shadowing, evidence in divorce and court proof”. One indicator of their demand is the rising footfall from women clients. “When I started my career,” says Malathy, “agencies were facing problems with women clients.” Women were reluctant to walk into a detective’s office, disclose family issues in front of men, or were scared of being identified. “I’d meet them at, say, the Radha Silk Emporium or in some temple.” But women are much less inhibited when they find a woman detective. “That’s why most agencies are setting up a woman’s wings,” she says.

Pandit faces such issues from 90 per cent of her clients. She recalls a family where thefts became rampant after a new bride arrived. The culprit

“If you have confidence and knowledge, you don’t face bias...”

**TARALIKA LAHIRI, 48**

**HEAD OF:** National Detectives and Corporate Consultants in Delhi

**FIRST CASE:** As a marketing executive with a security devices company, was sent to Allahabad to help out with a case of embezzlement in a bank. She cracked the case and found her calling.

**PERSONALITY QUIRK:** Inquisitive and adventurous by nature

**JOB PROFILE:** Corporate undercover operations, job and character verification, competitive business intelligence, matrimonial and teen issues

VIKRAM SHARMA

